Elevate HER Wellness

COMMON MISTAKES GUIDE

Identify, Correct, and Master Form for Functional Power & Injury Prevention



Dr. Rosanne Woods, PhD

COMMON MISTAKES & FORM GUIDE

How to Train Smarter, Safer, and More Effectively

Introduction: The Foundation of Strength

Strength training stands as one of the most potent tools available for enhancing your overall health, offering benefits that range from increased bone density to improved metabolic function. However, the true value of your training isn't found just in the amount of weight you lift, but in how you perform each movement. The way you interact with resistance dictates which muscles are activated and how your joints absorb the load. Even small technical errors—such as improper foot placement or a rounded spine—can create a "leak" in your power output, significantly reducing the effectiveness of the exercise and slowing your overall progress.

Beyond just stalling your gains, poor mechanics can increase the risk of persistent discomfort or acute injury. When the body is out of alignment, stress is often diverted away from the target muscles and onto connective tissues that aren't designed to handle such force. It is important to remember, however, that good form is not about achieving unattainable perfection or looking like a textbook illustration. Instead, it is about developing consistency and control.

By focusing on a stable, repeatable movement pattern, you ensure that every repetition serves its intended purpose. True mastery comes from the ability to maintain your technique even as fatigue sets in, allowing you to train harder and longer while keeping your body resilient.

Achieving Your Peak Potential: The Goals of This Guide

The primary objective of this guide is to provide you with a comprehensive roadmap for refining your fitness journey. By learning to recognize common mistakes, you can proactively identify the subtle errors in form or programming that often led to plateaus or unnecessary injury. Awareness is the first step toward correction, ensuring that you aren't just working hard, but working correctly.

We are aiming to bridge the gap between effort and execution by helping you improve movement quality. Beyond simply lifting weights or hitting cardio targets, focusing on the mechanics of your body allows for better muscle recruitment and long-term joint health. As you master these fundamentals, you will naturally begin to train with more confidence, shedding the hesitation that comes with being unsure of your technique. This mental shift is crucial; when you trust your body's ability to perform, you can push through barriers that previously seemed insurmountable.

Ultimately, this guide is designed to ensure you get better results from each workout. We want to maximize the "return on investment" for every minute you spend in the gym. By optimizing your approach and eliminating inefficiencies, you will see faster progress, more consistent gains, and a more sustainable path toward your personal health and performance goals.

The "Mistake Proof" Manual: Mastering Your Mechanics

Lifting weights in midlife is one of the most proactive things you can do for your health, but "sloppy" reps are a wasted opportunity. Below are the most frequent errors I see in the gym and—more importantly—how to fix them instantly to ensure every rep is a deposit into your longevity bank.

1. The "Midlife Slouch" (Upper Body Pulls)

- **The Mistake:** During rows or lat pulldowns, many women initiate the pull with their chin or by "shrugging" their shoulders up toward their ears. This leads to neck tension and prevents the back muscles (the lats) from doing the work.
- **The Fix: "Shoulders to Back Pockets."** Before you pull, imagine you are tucking your shoulder blades down and into your back pockets. Lead with your elbows, not your hands.

2. The "Valgus Collapse" (Squats & Step-Ups)

- **The Mistake:** As you squat or step up, your knees cave inward toward each other. This puts immense stress on the ACL and the meniscus.
- **The Fix: "Screw Your Feet into the Floor."** Imagine you are trying to tear a piece of paper apart between your feet. This creates "external rotation" at the hip, which automatically keeps your knees tracking safely over your second toe.

3. The "Butt Wink" & Over-Arching (Deadlifts & Pressing)

- **The Mistake:** Either rounding the lower back at the bottom of a deadlift or excessively arching the lower back during an overhead press. Both leave your spine vulnerable.
- **The Fix: "Ribs to Hips."** Think of your core as a cylinder. Keep your ribs "knitted" down toward your hip bones. If you feel your lower back arching during a press, squeeze your glutes as hard as you can, "locks" your pelvis into a safe, neutral position.

4. Moving Too Slow on the "Up" (The Power Gap)

- **The Mistake:** Performing the entire exercise at a "leisurely" pace. While control is good, moving slowly on the lifting phase fails to recruit those vital Type II (fast twitch) muscle fibers we are trying to save.
- **The Fix: "Slow Down, Snap Up."** In Phase 3, I want the lowering phase to be a controlled 3-count, but the lifting phase should be an **explosive 1-count**. Move weight like you mean it!

5. The "Ego Lift" vs. The "Empty Rep"

- **The Mistake:** Using weight so heavy that your form breaks down OR using weights so light that you could do 50 reps without breaking a sweat. Neither leads to the "Metabolic Spark" we need.
- **The Fix: Target the RPE 8.** You should finish your set feeling like you could have done 2 more "perfect" reps, but definitely not 5. If your form gets "ugly," the weight is too heavy. If you aren't breathing hard by the end, it's too light.

Dr. Rosanne's Pro-Tip:

"Form isn't about looking 'pretty' in the gym. It's about **Force Distribution**. When your form is correct, the load goes into your muscles and bones (where we want it) and stays out of your discs and tendons (where we don't)."

Exercise-Specific Mastery: The "Feel, Fix, & Flow" Guide

Use this guide as you move through Workouts A, B, and C. If an exercise feels "off," look here first to troubleshoot your mechanics.

1. The Goblet Squat (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** You should feel your weight balanced in your mid-foot. Your quads and glutes should be doing the heavy lifting, while your core feels like a rigid brace holding the weight steady.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Tip-Toe Squat."** Allowing your heels to lift off the floor as you descend, which shifts all the pressure into your kneecaps.
- **How to fix your form:** Imagine your feet are glued to the floor. Focus on sitting your hips *back* into a chair rather than just bending your knees *down*. If your heels still lift, place a small weight plate or a book under your heels to allow for better depth while maintaining a flat foot.

2. The Romanian Deadlift (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** A deep "pulling" or stretching sensation in your hamstrings (the back of your legs) as you lower the weight, followed by a powerful "squeeze" of the glutes to stand back up.
- **The Common Mistake: "Fishing for the Floor."** Reaching the weights toward your toes by rounding your spine. This turns a leg exercise into a dangerous back exercise.
- **How to fix your form:** Keep the weights shaving your legs, literally touching your shins the whole time. Your vertical depth doesn't matter; your horizontal hip reach does. Stop lowering once your hips stop moving backward.

3. The Weighted Step-Up (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** The "working" leg (the one on the box) should feel like a piston. You should feel a strong burn in the glute and quad of that leg, with very little "push" coming from the floor.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Springboard Effect."** Using your bottom foot to "hop" or push off the ground to get to the top.
- **How to fix your form:** Lift your bottom toes off the ground before you step up. This forces the top leg to do 100% of the work. Control the way down for a 3-second count, this "eccentric" phase is where the most muscle is built!

4. The Overhead Shoulder Press (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** Shoulders burning, but your spine is feeling "tall." You should feel your abs engage to keep you from leaning back.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lean Back."** Arching your lower back to help "cheat" the weight up. This is usually a sign that the weight is too heavy, or your core is "turned off."
- **How to fix your form:** Squeeze your glutes like you're trying to crush a walnut between them. This "anchors" your pelvis. If you still find yourself leaning, try the **Half-Kneeling Press** (one knee on the floor) to take your lower back out of the equation.

5. The One-Arm Row (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** A "pinch" between your shoulder blade and your spine at the top of the movement. Your grip might get tired, but your mid-back should be the primary driver.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lawn-Mower Pull."** Pulling the weight straight up to your armpit and rotating your torso toward the ceiling.
- **How to fix your form:** Pull the weight toward your hip, not your chest. Keep your shoulders square to the floor like headlights. Think about driving your elbow toward the back wall.

6. The Dead Bug (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** Your lower back should feel like it is "stapled" to the mat. You should feel a deep, intense tension in your lower abdominals (the transverse abdominis).
- **The Common Mistake: "The Arching Spine."** Letting the lower back pop off the floor as your leg extends. If you can slide a hand under your back, the core is no longer working.
- **How to fix your form:** Only lower your leg as far as you can without your back moving. If that’s only a few inches, that’s perfectly fine! Quality of the "brace" is more important than the range of motion.

7. The Push-Up (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** Tension across the chest and the back of the arms (triceps). Your entire body should feel like a rigid, moving plank—nothing from your ears to your ankles should sag.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Sagging Hips" or "Pike Neck."** Dropping the hips toward the floor or reaching with the chin to "finish" the rep early.

- **How to fix your form:** Squeeze your glutes and quads to keep your bridge strong. If you cannot maintain a straight line, move to an **Incline Push-Up** (hands on a bench or counter). This allows you to master the full range of motion without sacrificing your spine.

8. The Farmer's Carry (Workout A)

- **What it should feel like:** Your heart rate will climb, and your grip will burn. You should feel "active" height, like a string is pulling the top of your head toward the ceiling.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Side-to-Side Sway."** Letting the weights bounce against your thighs or allowing your torso to tilt.
- **How to fix your form:** Take small, "heel-to-toe" steps. Imagine you are walking on a tightrope while carrying two heavy suitcases you don't want to touch your legs. Keep your ribs tucked.

9. The Lat Pulldown (Workout B)

- **What it should feel like:** A "spreading" sensation across your mid-back as you pull. You should feel your shoulder blades moving down and together.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Lean & Rock."** Leaning back excessively (>45 degrees) and using momentum to "swing" the weight down.
- **How to fix your form:** Sit tall with a very slight lean. Focus on driving your elbows to your ribs. Imagine there is a grape between your shoulder blades that you are trying to crush at the bottom of the rep.

10. The Sumo Squat (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** Increased engagement in the inner thighs (adductors) and deep glutes. You should feel "wider" and more stable than a traditional squat.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Knee Cave."** Because the stance is wide, knees often want to collapse inward.
- **How to fix your form:** Point your toes out at 45 degrees and consciously push your knees *out* so they stay stacked directly over your ankles. Think about "opening the book" with your knees.

11. The Single-Leg Deadlift (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** A massive amount of work in the standing leg's glute and ankle stabilizers. It's a test of "quiet strength."
- **The Common Mistake: "The Hip Opening."** Letting the hip of the floating leg rotate toward the ceiling, which takes the tension off the working glute.

- **How to fix your form:** Keep the toes of your floating foot pointed straight at the ground. Imagine your hips are headlights; they must both shine straight down at the floor throughout the entire movement.

12. The Low-to-High Band Press (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** A diagonal "slingshot" effect. You should feel your core and obliques working to stabilize the rotation, and your shoulder finishing the movement.
- **The Common Mistake: "Arm-Only Movement."** Standing with "cement feet" and only using the shoulder to move the band.
- **How to fix your form:** Pivot on your back foot like you're throwing a punch or swinging a golf club. The power comes from your hips and core; the arm just delivers it.

13. The Face Pull (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** A burn in the back of the shoulders and between the shoulder blades. It should feel like you are "opening up" your chest.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Chin Poke."** Reaching forward with the neck to meet the band.
- **How to fix your form:** Keep your chin tucked. Pull the band toward your forehead, not your chest, and focus on pulling the ends of the band *apart* as you get closer to your face.

14. The Bird-Dog (Workout C)

- **What it should feel like:** Stability and length. You should feel a line of tension from your fingertips to the opposite heel.
- **The Common Mistake: "The Sky Kick."** Kicking the back leg too high, which causes the lower back to arch and "dump" the tension.
- **How to fix your form:** Kick back, not up. Imagine you are trying to push a button on the wall behind you with your heel. Keep your back flat enough to hold a bowl of soup.

"Consistency over Intensity. Precision over Ego."

Use this guide for the first 14 days until these cues become second nature. When your brain and muscles speak the same language, the Power follows naturally.

Dr. Rosanne's Final Form Rule:

"If you can't control the weight, you aren't ready for the weight. In midlife, we build power on a foundation of precision. Master the 'Feel,' apply the 'Fix,' and the 'Flow' will follow."

Conclusion: Your Strength is Your Future

Embracing strength training in midlife is more than just a fitness choice; it is a profound act of self-care and a direct investment in your future independence. While it's natural to feel a bit of trepidation when picking up a set of dumbbells for the first time, especially with the fear of "doing it wrong", remember that every expert was once a beginner. The nuances of form and technique we've covered aren't meant to be barriers, but rather the very tools that will empower you to move with grace, power, and resilience.

By prioritizing consistency over perfection, you are doing more than just building muscle; you are protecting your bone density, boosting your metabolism, and reclaiming your physical narrative. You have the wisdom to listen to your body and the discipline to refine your craft. Don't let the weight room intimidate you—you belong there. As you apply these principles of control and alignment, you'll find that the strength you build within the gym walls inevitably spills over into every other aspect of your life.

"Strength training is the closest thing we have to a fountain of youth. It's never too late to start, and you are never too old to get stronger."

Now is the time to step into your power. Grab those weights, trust your preparation, and watch as your body rewards you with a level of vitality and confidence you may have thought was behind you. Your strongest chapter is just beginning.